



Danger in paradise

The beautiful Caribbean islands (this idyllic beach is in Cuba) attract thousands of visitors with considerable spending power. The same landscapes, though, are also vulnerable to severe weather conditions such as hurricanes, which regularly destroy lives and property.



The islands of the Caribbean feature white sandy beaches fringed with graceful palm trees.

HOME AND AWAY

British colonists introduced the game of cricket to the islands they settled. West Indian players, like these in Barbados, are now among the best in the world.



MAKING MUSIC

This region has produced some of the most influential musical styles of recent years, from the *ranchera* sounds of Central America, to styles as diverse as mambo, rumba, calypso, and reggae from the West Indies. This traditional steel-drum band is performing in Soufriere, Saint Lucia.



Steel drums evoke the Caribbean wherever they're played.

GROWING THINGS

A wide range of fruit and vegetables is grown in the region. Some of this produce is sold for export, but much of it ends up in colorful street markets like this one on Grand Bahama Island.



CELEBRATION

Catholicism is the dominant religion in Central America. To celebrate Good Friday in Antigua, Guatemala, the streets are covered with *alfombras*, or "carpets" made from painted sawdust.

